

PEOPLES OF CENTRAL AND SOUTH AMERICA

Population: approximately 433,500,000 people
Number of countries: 32

THE LANGUAGE, HISTORY, and culture of Central and South America have been shaped by colonization. Until 1492, when Christopher Columbus first landed in the Bahamas, the continent was inhabited by native peoples. After that time, European settlers arrived from Spain and Portugal, and huge numbers of Africans were imported as slaves, especially to the Caribbean and Brazil. The Caribbean also became home to English, French, and Dutch settlers. As a result, the population of the continent today is a combination of these different ethnic groups. Spanish is the main language spoken throughout most of the continent, together with Portuguese in Brazil. English and French are more common in the Caribbean, while Dutch can still be heard in Suriname.



Magnificent Catholic churches, such as the Church of St. Francisco in Brazil, are a lasting reminder of colonial rule.



SPANISH INFLUENCE
 From the 16th century on, Spain and Portugal colonized South America. Both countries also sent missionaries to spread the Roman Catholic religion. Spain colonized much of the continent, but Portuguese-ruled Brazil became the largest and most economically powerful country. Today, the majority of South Americans are still Roman Catholics.

ETHNIC GROUPS

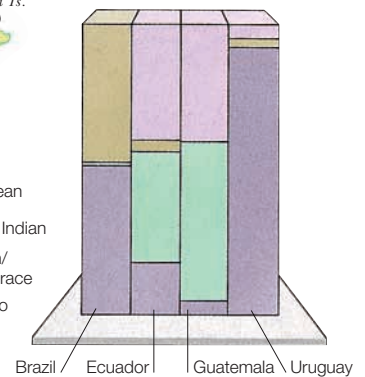
Native Indians, who can trace their history back to people living in Central and South America before the Europeans arrived, make up just 2 percent of the continent's population today. The next largest group are people of African descent, the greatest number of whom are today found in Brazil and the Caribbean. In most countries, the largest group of people is of mixed European and native Indian descent, known as *mestizos*.



Key

- European
- Native Indian
- African/mixed race
- Mestizo

Ethnic groups



These young Brazilian men are a mix of ethnic groups.

The peoples of Central and South America can be divided into four distinct ethnic groups. This chart shows what proportion of the population makes up each of the four ethnic groups in four countries.